

16 Past tenses overview

16.1 PAST TENSES

The **past simple** refers to a single, completed action in the past.

Phil **washed** his car on Tuesday.

This is a completed action in the past that is now over.

The **past continuous** refers to a continuing action in the past.

The last time I saw Phil, he **was washing** his car.

At that moment, he was in the process of washing his car.

The **present perfect simple** refers to an unfinished action or series of actions that started in the past, or past actions that still have a consequence in the present moment.

Eve **has arrived** in London.

Eve is still in London, so it is still relevant to the present moment.

The **present perfect continuous** refers to a continuing activity in the past that still has a consequence in the present moment.

I **have been** painting the house all day. I'm exhausted!

This is a consequence in the present moment.

16.2 PAST SIMPLE AND PRESENT PERFECT SIMPLE

The **past simple** is used to refer to single, completed actions or events in the past. These no longer have a consequence in the present moment.



I **wrote** my essay about Ancient Greece.

The essay is finished, so the past simple is used.



I **lost** my keys, but I **found** them on my desk.

This is no longer relevant to the present moment, because the keys were found.

The **present perfect simple** is used to refer to actions or events in the past that are unfinished, or still have consequences in the present moment.



I **have written** half of my essay, but I need to finish it.

The essay is unfinished, so the present perfect simple is used.



I **have lost** my keys. I can't find them anywhere!

The keys are still lost in the present moment, so the present perfect simple is used.